

## BONUS RESOURCE

# The PowerPoint Storytelling Kit

Frameworks and prompt starters for decks that actually land

- Four narrative frameworks, with the prompt that builds each one
- How to use Narrative Builder to turn a document into a first draft that already has a spine
- Slide-by-slide prompts for openers, data, comparisons, closers and speaker notes
- A design pass, a brand-compliance pass and a rehearsal pass before anything ships

Current as of September 2026. Assumes Microsoft 365 Copilot in PowerPoint on the web or desktop, and a Microsoft 365 Copilot licence.

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## 1 Structure before slides

Decide the argument before you open PowerPoint

The decks that land are not the ones with the best slides. They are the ones where someone decided the argument before opening PowerPoint. Copilot is very good at building slides and mediocre at deciding what a talk is actually for - so that decision has to be yours, made first, in one sentence.

### 1 Write the one-sentence takeaway

If the audience remembers exactly one thing on their way out, what is it? Not a topic - a claim. "We should invest in X" is a takeaway. "An update on X" is not.

### 2 Name the audience's starting position

Are they skeptical, bought-in, uninformed, or actively opposed? The same content needs a different opening for each.

### 3 Pick the one job the deck does

Inform, persuade, or decide. A deck trying to do all three usually does none of them well - decide which one before you ask Copilot for anything.

### 4 Only then choose a framework

Section 2 has four. Naming the takeaway and the job first is what makes the framework prompt in the next section return something built around your argument instead of a generic template.

## HAVE COPILOT HELP YOU CHOOSE

*"I need to decide the structure for a presentation before I build it. My one-sentence takeaway is [takeaway]. The audience is [description], starting from [their current position]. The deck needs to [inform / persuade / help them decide]. Suggest which narrative framework fits best and why."*

## 2 Four frameworks, and the prompt for each

Pick the shape that matches the job you named in section 1

Four shapes cover almost everything a business presentation needs to do. Pick the one that matches the job you named in section 1, then hand Copilot the prompt underneath it.

### Situation - Complication - Resolution

**Best for: persuading a skeptical or neutral audience toward a decision.**

Where things stand, what has changed or gone wrong, and what you propose doing about it. The workhorse structure for a business case.

*"Build a presentation using Situation, Complication, Resolution. Situation: [current state]. Complication: [what changed or the problem]. Resolution: [your proposal]. Ground every slide in [document/data], and end with a single clear ask."*

## Problem - Agitate - Solve

**Best for: an audience that does not yet feel the urgency.**

State the problem, make its cost and consequences concrete before offering relief, then present the solution as the release of tension you just built.

*"Build a presentation using Problem, Agitate, Solve. Problem: [problem]. Agitate: quantify the cost of not acting, using [data/document]. Solve: [your solution]. Do not introduce the solution until the cost of inaction is established."*

## Before - After - Bridge

**Best for: pitching a change, a product, or a new way of working.**

Paint the current state, paint the improved state, then show the bridge - what has to happen to get from one to the other. Concrete and easy to follow.

*"Build a presentation using Before, After, Bridge. Before: [current state]. After: [the improved state if we succeed]. Bridge: [the concrete steps or investment that gets us there]. Make the After slide vivid enough that the Bridge feels worth it."*

## Chronological narrative

**Best for: a retrospective, a project story, or anything with a genuine timeline.**

What happened, in order, with the turning points called out. Works only when the sequence itself is the interesting part - forcing it onto content with no real timeline produces a boring deck.

*"Build a presentation telling the story of [project/period] in chronological order from [document]. Call out the two or three turning points where direction changed, and end on where things stand now."*

A framework is a shape for an argument, not a slide count. Ask Copilot to build within the framework using your material - never ask it to "make this more like Situation-Complication-Resolution" on a deck that was not written to argue anything. That produces slides with the right headers and no actual argument underneath.

## 3 From document to draft: Narrative Builder

The fastest path to a first draft that already has a spine

If you already have a Word document, report or set of notes, Narrative Builder is the fastest path to a first draft with a spine - not a slide-per-paragraph dump of the source document.

1

### Start from the Copilot pane, not a blank deck

Open the Copilot pane in PowerPoint and choose "Create presentation from file." Point it at your Word document, or paste the file's link.

2

**Steer the story before it builds**

Narrative Builder lets you add and reorder the topics it plans to use before generating a single slide. This is the moment to enforce the framework and takeaway from sections 1 and 2 - do not skip straight to "generate."

3

**Let it draft, then edit the spine, not the wording**

The first draft will have reasonable slides in a mediocre order more often than it will have wrong content. Fix structure first with prompts, then polish language.

4

**Add what the document does not contain**

Narrative Builder only knows what is in the source file. Data, quotes or images that live elsewhere need to be added with follow-up prompts once the draft exists.

**PROMPTS FOR STEERING AND FIXING THE DRAFT**

*"Create a presentation from [document], steering the narrative toward: [your takeaway]. Use the Situation-Complication-Resolution framework and keep it to 10 slides."*

*"Reorder these slides so the strongest evidence comes right after the problem is introduced, not at the end."*

*"This draft summarises the document but does not argue anything. Rewrite the slide titles as claims, not topics - each one should state what the slide proves."*

*"Which slides in this draft are filler that could be cut without losing the argument?"*

4

**Slide-by-slide prompts**

Different slides do different jobs - reach for the right one

Different slides do different jobs. These prompts are grouped by the job, so you reach for the right one instead of asking Copilot to "make a slide about X" and hoping.

**OPENERS**

*"Write an opening slide that states the takeaway in one sentence, not a topic title. The audience should know the conclusion before slide two."*

*"Write a cold open using a single striking number from [data/document] that sets up why this matters before any context is given."*

*"Write an opener that names the audience's likely objection and promises to address it, so skeptics stay engaged rather than checking out early."*

**TRANSITIONS**

*"Write a one-line transition slide moving from the problem section into the solution section, that makes the shift feel earned rather than abrupt."*

*"This deck jumps between topics with no connective tissue. Suggest transition lines between each section."*

## COMPARISONS AND OPTIONS

*"Build a slide comparing [option A] and [option B] on the same three criteria, so the trade-off is visual rather than buried in a paragraph."*

*"Turn this list of pros and cons into a single slide that makes the recommended option's advantage obvious at a glance."*

## CLOSERS

*"Write a closing slide with a single clear ask: what I want the audience to do, by when."*

*"Write a closing slide that restates the takeaway from the opener in different words, so the argument feels like it closed a loop."*

*"This deck ends on a summary slide with no ask. Rewrite it so the last thing the audience sees is a decision, not a recap."*

## 5 Data slides that make the point

A chart with no argument attached is decoration

A chart with no argument attached is decoration. Every data slide prompt here forces a point, not just a visualisation, onto the slide.

*"Turn this data into a slide that makes one point: [the point]. Choose whichever chart type proves it fastest, and title the slide with the conclusion, not the metric name."*

*"This chart has six data series and no clear message. Simplify it to show only what supports [the argument], and move the rest to an appendix slide."*

*"Write a title for this chart that states what it proves, not what it contains - "Revenue by quarter" tells the audience nothing; the title should."*

*"Build a single slide contrasting [before metric] and [after metric] so the change is the entire visual, with no other information competing for attention."*

*"Suggest which of these five charts is strongest for a skeptical audience, and which look impressive but do not actually support the argument."*

One slide, one number, one point. If a data slide needs a paragraph of spoken explanation to land, the chart chose the wrong emphasis - fix the chart before you write the explanation.

## 6 The design pass

Polish after the structure is right, never before

Do this after the structure is right, never before. Polishing slides whose argument is still wrong wastes the polish.

*"Redesign this slide - it has too much text for the point it is making. Cut it to what someone could read in five seconds."*

*"This slide is visually busy. Suggest a simpler layout that keeps the same information."*

*"Make the visual hierarchy on this slide clearer - what should the eye land on first, and does the current design achieve that?"*

*"Add an image that reinforces [the point] on this slide, in a style that matches the rest of the deck."*

*"Check this deck for consistent formatting: fonts, spacing, and title style across every slide."*

*"This slide has three ideas competing for attention. Split it into two slides, one idea each."*

Ask for the diagnosis before the redesign on anything you are attached to: "what is wrong with this slide" before "fix this slide." It is easier to accept a rebuild when you understand what earned it.

## 7 Brand and compliance

Build within the template, do not reformat after the fact

Copilot in PowerPoint can build directly from a branded template or file rather than a generic one, carrying over your organisation's fonts, colours and layouts, and can draw on approved image libraries where your organisation has connected them.

### Start from your template

Open your organisation's .potx file or a previous on-brand deck first, then ask Copilot to build within it, rather than generating a generic design and reformatting afterward.

### Ask for a compliance check

"Check this deck against our brand guidelines and flag anything off" catches drifted fonts, wrong colours or off-template layouts before someone else notices.

### Use approved imagery

Where your organisation has connected a brand asset library, ask Copilot to pull images from it by name rather than generating or sourcing new visuals that may not be cleared for use.

### Keep formatting through edits

Structural edits - reordering, adding, cutting slides - should preserve the template's formatting. If a prompt breaks the brand styling, undo and re-ask more specifically: "add a slide about X, matching the existing template."

## 8 Speaker notes and rehearsal

The deck is not the talk

The deck is not the talk. These prompts build what you will actually say, and what happens when someone asks the question you were hoping to avoid.

*"Write speaker notes for this slide: what I say while it is on screen, in a conversational tone, under 45 seconds spoken."*

*"Write speaker notes that do not repeat the slide text - they should add the context and reasoning the slide does not have room for."*

*"What is the hardest question I could get after this slide, and what is a strong two-sentence answer?"*

*"Summarise this deck into a 30-second verbal version I could give if my time got cut to one minute."*

*"Where in this deck am I most likely to lose the audience's attention, and what would bring it back?"*

*"List every claim in this deck that someone could reasonably challenge, so I can prepare an answer for each before I present."*

Run the hardest-question prompt on your three most important slides, not the whole deck. The value is in preparing for the moment that could actually derail you, not in generating a script for everything.

## 9 When it does not work

Symptoms, causes and fixes

Where PowerPoint Copilot commonly disappoints, and what is usually behind it.

| Symptom                                              | Almost always the cause                                                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Deck reads like a document, not a talk</b>        | Built without a takeaway or framework decided first. Go back to section 1 and rebuild the structure before touching wording.                                                 |
| <b>Slides are generic and off-brand</b>              | Started from a blank presentation instead of your organisation's template or a previous on-brand file. Start from the template next time and ask Copilot to build within it. |
| <b>Narrative Builder ignored part of my document</b> | It only draws on the file provided - check whether the missing content was in a linked file, an image, or a table it could not parse well.                                   |
| <b>Chart looks right but proves nothing</b>          | The chart was requested before the point was decided. State the point in the prompt, not just the data and chart type.                                                       |
| <b>Speaker notes just repeat the slide</b>           | Ask explicitly for notes that add context the slide does not have room for, rather than a spoken version of the bullet points.                                               |
| <b>A structural edit broke the formatting</b>        | Undo, and re-ask with the template referenced explicitly: "matching the existing template" or "preserving the current formatting."                                           |



# QUICK REFERENCE

## The PowerPoint Storytelling Kit

### BEFORE YOU OPEN POWERPOINT

- Write the one-sentence takeaway - a claim, not a topic
- Name the audience's starting position
- Decide the one job: inform, persuade, or decide
- Pick a framework: SCR, Problem-Agitate-Solve, Before-After-Bridge, or chronological

### BUILD THE DRAFT

- Start from your branded template or file, not a blank deck
- Use Narrative Builder from a document; steer the topics before it generates
- Fix structure with prompts before you polish wording

### STRENGTHEN IT

- One slide, one number, one point for every data slide
- Title charts with the conclusion, not the metric
- Ask what is wrong before asking for a redesign
- Check against brand guidelines before it goes anywhere

### BEFORE YOU PRESENT

- Write notes that add context, not repeat the slide
- Ask for the hardest likely question on your top three slides
- Have a 30-second version ready in case your time gets cut

*Copilot can build the slides in minutes. It cannot decide what you are trying to convince someone of. Spend your time on the argument - the deck that carries it well is now the fast part.*